Philosophy: An Investigation of Structural Similarity with the Five-Stage Model

2026-03-23

Contents

Philosophy: An Investigation of Structural Similarity with the Five-Stage Model 2
1. Purpose and Question of the Investigation . . . 2
2. Method of Investigation . . . 3
3. Overview of the Model . . . 4
4. Results: Overall Picture . . . 4
5. Results: Main Findings . . . 5
6. Cross-Domain Patterns . . . 8
7. Unresolved Questions . . . 10
8. Conclusion . . . 11

Philosophy: An Investigation of Structural Similarity with the Five-Stage Model

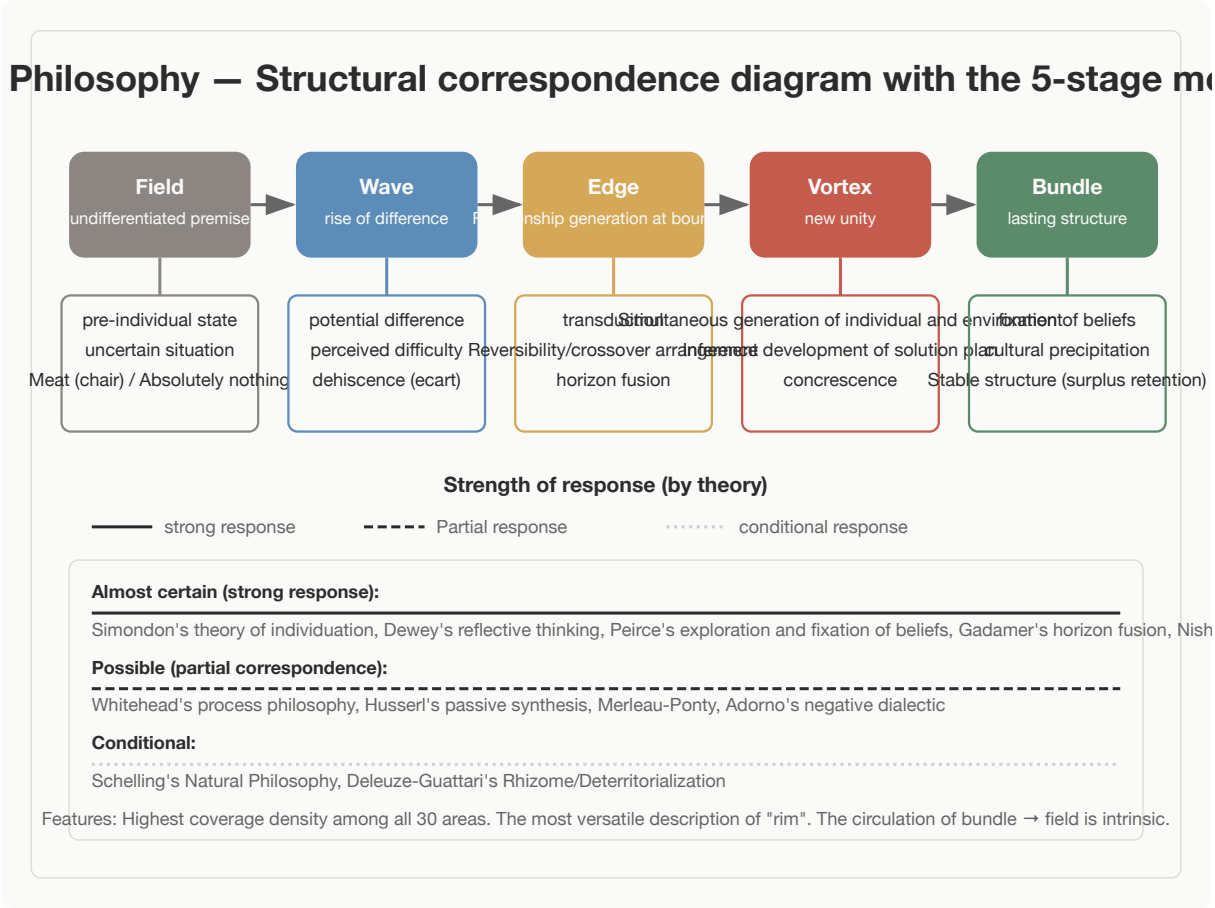

Figure 1: Philosophy: An Investigation of Structural Similarity with the Five-Stage Model — Structural correspondence diagram

1. Purpose and Question of the Investigation

This report is written to answer a single question.

> Do the theories of philosophy correspond structurally to the five-stage model, Field -> Wave -> Edge -> Vortex -> Bundle?

This investigation is part of a larger project examining thirty academic domains in order to test whether a common structure can be found in creative process. The present report presents the results for philosophy, domain D13.

What this report does not do: It is not a document intended to support or justify any particular philosophy. It reports, on the basis of investigation data, whether structural correspondence can be seen between the five-stage model and each theory, whether it cannot, or whether the correspondence is conditional. Readers do not need to accept the conclusions uncritically; the evidence presented here can be checked independently.

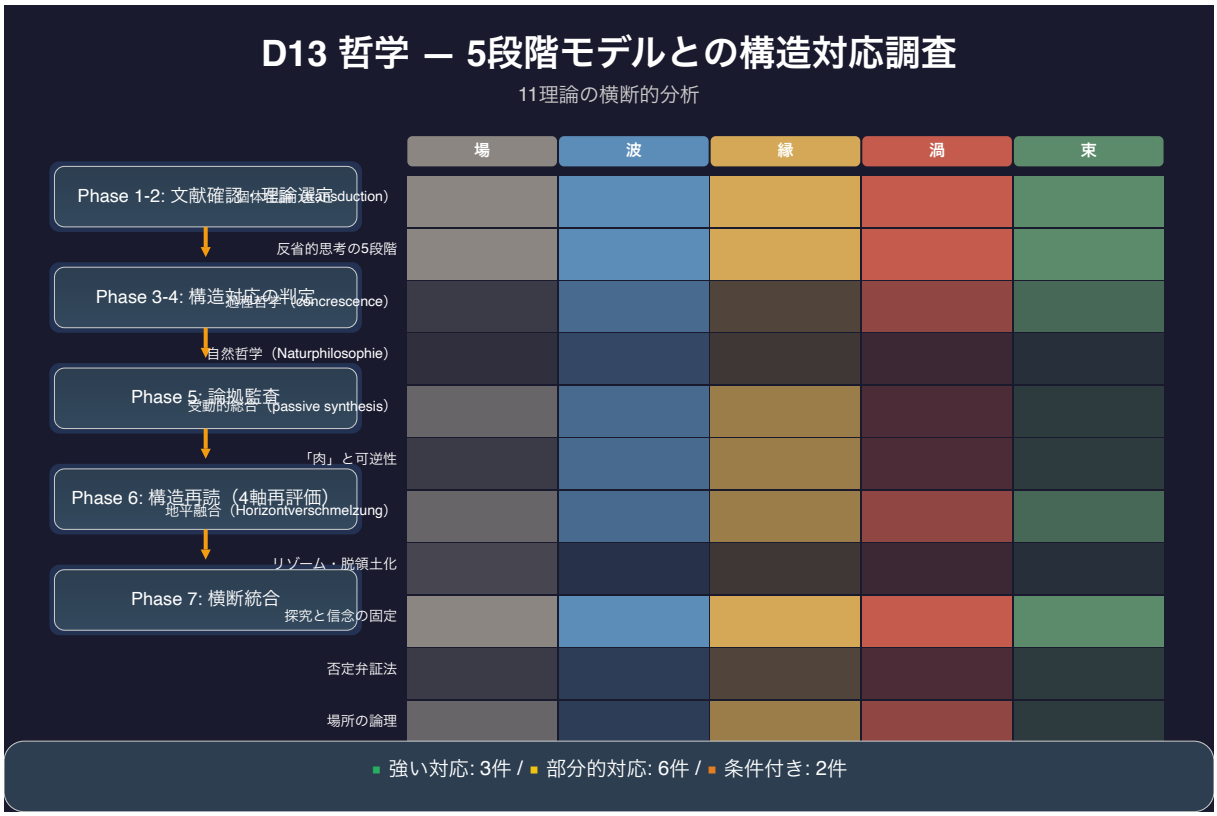

Figure 2: Philosophy: An Investigation of Structural Similarity with the Five-Stage Model —

2. Method of Investigation

Objects and Selection Criteria

Philosophy has spent more than two thousand years asking about creation, becoming, and the origin of being. In this investigation, eleven theories were selected from seven lineages spanning ontology, epistemology, and practical philosophy. The criteria were: (1) the theory takes creation, generation, or process as a central theme; (2) structural analysis is possible on the basis of primary texts; and (3) it provides a perspective sufficiently distinct from other philosophical traditions.

Method of Evaluation

For each theory, structural correspondence was examined between the theory and each stage of the five-stage model on the basis of primary texts. Judgments of correspondence were made from multiple independent angles, including concrete textual evidence, depth of structure, scope of the theory, and the risk of forced interpretation.

Criteria of Judgment

- **Strong structural correspondence**: Core concepts and mechanisms of the theory correspond to stages of the five-stage model with concrete textual support.
- **Partial correspondence**: Some stages correspond, but correspondence across all stages cannot be confirmed, or the evidence remains somewhat weaker.
- **Conditional correspondence**: Structural correspondence can be indicated, but because of the nature of the theory itself, such as polysemy of concepts or resistance to stage-based reading, caution is required.

Limits of the Investigation

Philosophy is a domain of extremely high abstraction, and therefore carries the risk that almost anything could be mapped onto anything else. This investigation recognizes that risk and attempts to control it through concrete citation of relevant passages, explicit self-evaluation of the risk of overreading, and critical comparison. It does not attempt a comprehensive reading of each philosopher's corpus, but focuses on the central concepts of major works.

3. Overview of the Model

The five-stage model describes creative process through the following five stages.

Stage	Definition
Field	An undifferentiated state, an initial condition in which neither direction nor structure has yet been fixed
Wave	A stage of exploration in which multiple directions diverge and compete
Edge	A tense condition in which opposing elements coexist without converging into either side
Vortex	A stage in which a new coherence or order rises spontaneously out of the tension
Bundle	A stage in which form is fixed and stabilizes as a reusable structure

This model is not a one-way linear sequence. It includes a cyclical structure in which Bundle becomes the condition for the next Field. The five stages are also not rigid boxes, but are better understood as a continuous spectrum. The hypothesis is that the same structure may recur across different scales, from momentary acts of thought to social and historical change.

If these definitions already feel uncomfortable, that is itself important for the present investigation. Readers can continue while holding onto that discomfort, or pause here and examine it directly.

4. Results: Overall Picture

The Eleven Theories Evaluated

In philosophy, eleven theories were evaluated across seven lineages.

Lineage	Theory	Proponent	Structural Correspondence
Ontological process philosophy	individuation theory	Simondon	Strong correspondence
Ontological process philosophy	process philosophy	Whitehead	Strong correspondence
Ontological process philosophy	philosophy of nature	Schelling	Conditional correspondence
Pragmatism	reflective thought	Dewey	Strong correspondence
Pragmatism	inquiry and fixation of belief	Peirce	Strong correspondence

Lineage	Theory	Proponent	Structural Correspondence
Phenomenology	passive synthesis	Husserl	Strong correspondence
Phenomenology	flesh and reversibility	Merleau-Ponty	Strong correspondence
Hermeneutics	fusion of horizons	Gadamer	Strong correspondence
Post-structuralism	rhizome and de-territorialization	Deleuze and Guattari	Conditional correspondence
Critical theory	negative dialectics	Adorno	Strong correspondence
Japanese philosophy	logic of basho	Nishida Kitaro	Strong correspondence

Of the eleven theories, nine showed strong structural correspondence. Two, Schelling and Deleuze-Guattari, showed conditional correspondence. No theory showed no correspondence at all.

Strength of Correspondence at Edge

Within the five stages, Edge is the core stage of creative process. The strength of Edge correspondence in each theory can be summarized as follows.

- **Strong Edge correspondence (6)**: Simondon, Dewey, Merleau-Ponty, Gadamer, Peirce, Nishida
- **Partial Edge correspondence (3)**: Whitehead, Husserl, Adorno
- **Weak Edge correspondence (1)**: Deleuze and Guattari
- **No concept directly corresponding to Edge (1)**: Schelling

The investigation suggests that philosophy is one of the domains able to describe Edge in the greatest variety of ways.

5. Results: Main Findings

The following sections focus on theories that proved especially suggestive.

5.1 Simondon: Describing the Genesis of Being on the Same Scale

Gilbert Simondon described how beings come to exist as individuals. He rejected the traditional hylomorphic model, according to which form exists in advance and matter is poured into it, and instead treated individuation as a continuous process.

In Simondon's theory of individuation, the point of departure is the preindividual metastable state. This is a condition that is neither fully stable nor unstable, but stores potential, an energetic surplus. A potential difference destabilizes that metastable state, corresponding to Wave, and local structuration then propagates into adjacent regions through what Simondon calls transduction, corresponding to Edge. Crystal growth is the standard example: once a seed crystal touches a supersaturated solution, structuration spreads outward from the contact surface. As a result of transduction, the individual and its milieu are generated together, corresponding to Vortex, and a stable structure is formed, corresponding to Bundle.

This correspondence is especially noteworthy because Simondon is addressing the same scope as the five-stage model, namely the genesis of being itself. The correspondence does not appear to rest on accidental similarity in number of stages, but on the fact that both are describing the same problem space through different vocabularies.

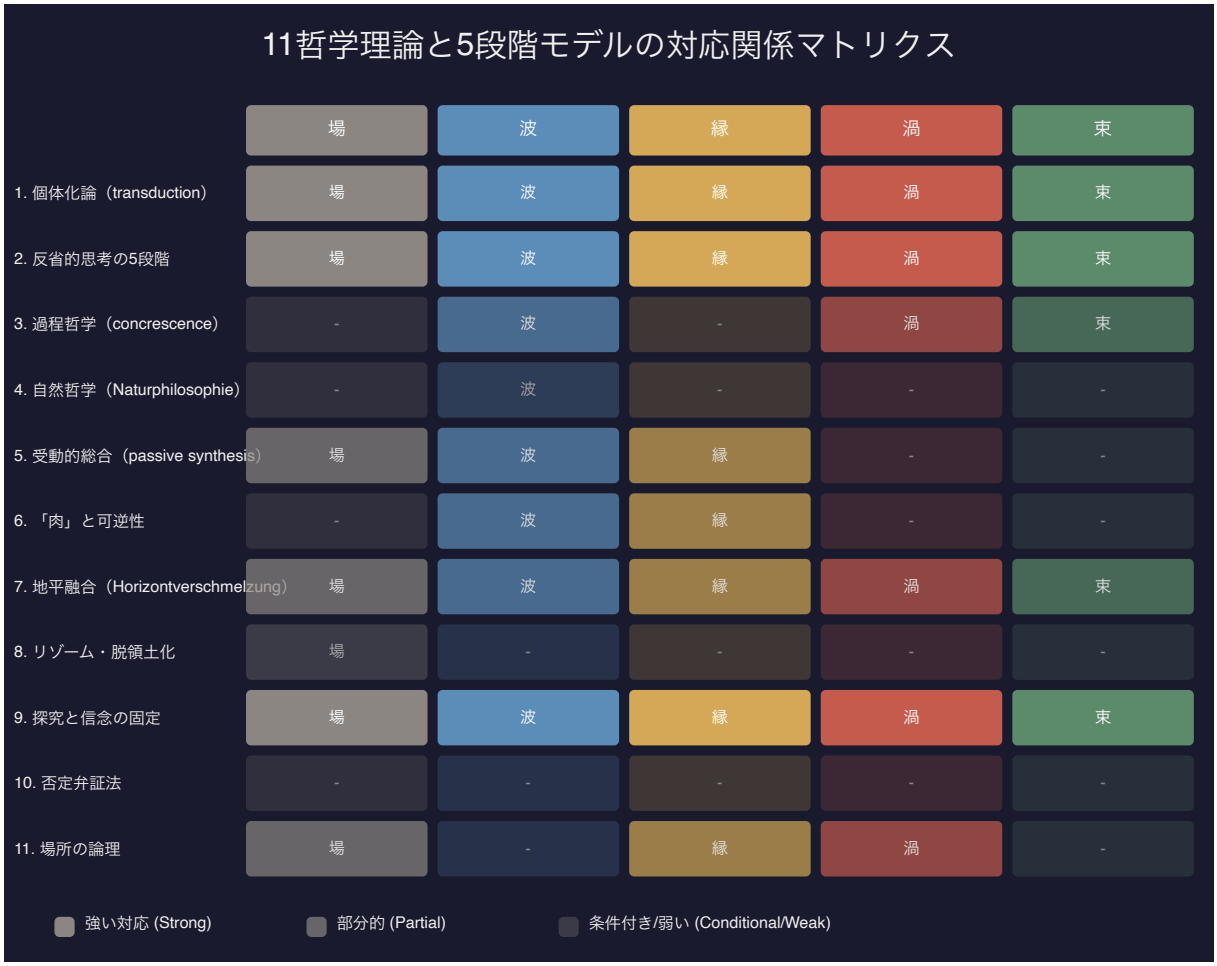

Figure 3: Philosophy: An Investigation of Structural Similarity with the Five-Stage Model — ×5

What is even more important is Simondon's concept of preindividual remainder. According to Simondon, individuation does not exhaust preindividual potential. A remainder always persists, and this becomes the seed of the next individuation. That provides an ontological answer to the Bundle -> Field cycle in the five-stage model: why the process does not simply end, but begins again.

5.2 Dewey: The Only Theory That Explicitly Lists Five Stages in a Primary Text

John Dewey, the American pragmatist philosopher, explicitly listed five logically distinct steps of reflective thought in chapter 6 of *How We Think*.

(i) a felt difficulty, (ii) its location and definition, (iii) suggestion of a possible solution, (iv) development by reasoning, and (v) further observation and experiment leading to acceptance or rejection.

These five stages are among the most direct structural correspondences found in the entire thirty-domain investigation. Felt difficulty corresponds to Wave, as the prereflective experience of discrepancy between expectation and reality. Locating and defining the difficulty corresponds to Edge, as the operation of formulating a vague difficulty in terms of relations among elements. Suggestion of a solution and its development by reasoning correspond to Vortex, as the stage in which a hypothesis rises as a coherent whole. Observation and experiment leading to adoption or rejection correspond to Bundle, as the stage in which belief stabilizes.

Because Dewey himself explicitly lists five stages, the risk of arbitrary external mapping is minimized. At the same time, two cautions are necessary. First, Dewey's five stages describe reflective thought, and any extension to creation of being in general still requires interpretation. Second, Dewey himself allows that stages can fuse, especially the first and second, so it would be unfaithful to read him as defending a rigidly linear five-step sequence.

In *Logic: The Theory of Inquiry* (1938), Dewey more generally defines inquiry as the controlled transformation of an indeterminate situation into a determinate one. That indeterminate situation is a state not yet formed into a problem, and is structurally isomorphic to Field.

5.3 Gadamer: Describing the Question as the Motor of Creation

Hans-Georg Gadamer, known for philosophical hermeneutics, described understanding in *Truth and Method* as a fusion of horizons.

Gadamer's hermeneutics corresponds to the five stages as follows. The interpreter always already stands within a horizon of fore-understanding, corresponding to Field. Encounter with a text or another person destabilizes that fore-understanding, corresponding to Wave. Out of that discrepancy there arises a question, Frage, corresponding to Edge. That question drives the hermeneutic circle, the back-and-forth between part and whole and between question and answer, corresponding to Vortex. Finally, fusion of horizons is achieved, corresponding to Bundle. The newly enlarged horizon becomes the precondition for the next act of understanding, that is, a new Field.

What matters especially here is the concept of question. For Gadamer, the question is both the condition and the result of understanding. To understand is to reconstruct the question to which the text is an answer. The question opens the direction of answer without determining it, showing indeterminacy. It arises at the boundary between fore-understanding and otherness, showing relationality. It drives the hermeneutic circle, showing connection to Vortex. These three features correspond with particular precision to the definition of Edge.

Another important insight is Gadamer's rehabilitation of prejudice. He criticizes the Enlightenment's prejudice against prejudice and argues that prejudice, Vorurteil, is not an obstacle

to understanding but one of its conditions. Without anticipation, there can be no error, and therefore no understanding or creation.

5.4 Merleau-Ponty: Describing Edge from the Body

Maurice Merleau-Ponty, the phenomenologist of embodiment, introduced the concept of flesh in *The Visible and the Invisible*. Flesh is neither matter nor mind, but the pre-differentiated element shared by subject and world.

In Merleau-Ponty's conceptual system, flesh corresponds to Field. Ecart, the minimal difference or gap within flesh, corresponds to Wave, because it initiates differentiation. Reversibility or chiasm corresponds to Edge.

Reversibility is the situation in which the touching hand is at the same time touchable. Merleau-Ponty insists that the difference between toucher and touched does not disappear, but remains as a gap, an ecart. The boundary between subject and object is therefore not fixed, but an interface of reversible mutual transformation. Yet reversibility never reaches full coincidence. A residual gap always remains. That very gap is what makes reversibility productive. Full identity would destroy relation and stop creation.

This bodily description of Edge provides a basis for understanding Edge not merely as an intellectual operation, but as a bodily process.

5.5 Nishida Kitaro: Providing an Ontological Basis for Field

Nishida Kitaro, founder of the Kyoto School, introduced the concept of basho in his 1926 essay of that name.

Nishida's basho has a three-layer structure: the place of being, the place of relative nothingness, and the place of absolute nothingness. This layered structure suggests that Field in the five-stage model may not be merely an empty space, but may possess depth.

Nishida's later concept of absolute contradictory self-identity is equally important. Individual things are the whole through self-negation, and the whole is individual through self-negation. This structure, in which contradictory elements remain connected while not collapsing into one another, describes the transition from Edge to Vortex. From Nishida's own standpoint, however, this is not a transition but a simultaneous event.

His notion of acting intuition, seeing is making and making is seeing, also suggests that the generation of understanding and the generation of being are two sides of the same event.

Nishida provides a perspective that relativizes assumptions common to many of the Western theories treated in the report, especially subject-predicate logic and substance ontology.

6. Cross-Domain Patterns

When the findings of the eleven theories are viewed together, a number of recurrent structures become visible.

6.1 Philosophical Diversity of Edge

Philosophy is one of the richest domains for describing Edge. Six distinct philosophical descriptions were obtained.

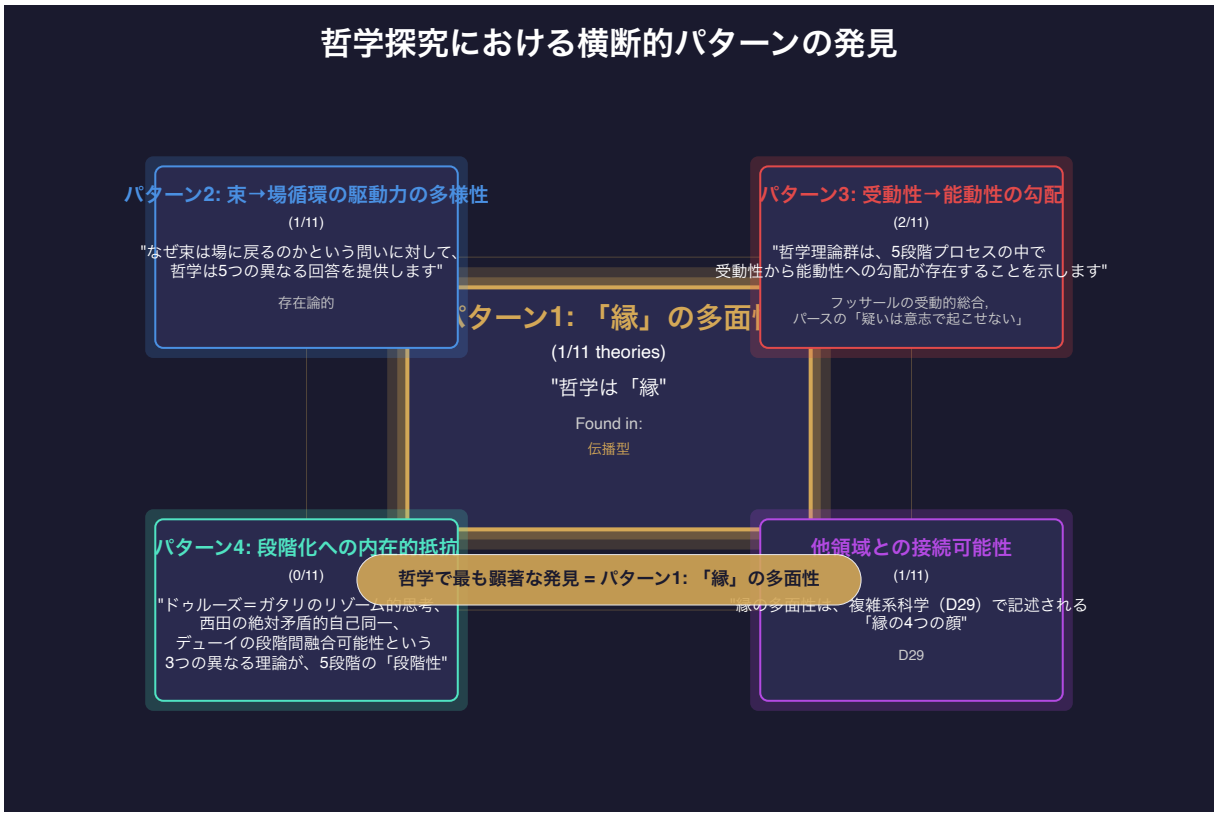

Figure 4: Philosophy: An Investigation of Structural Similarity with the Five-Stage Model —

Theory	Description of Edge	Character
Simondon	transduction, propagation of local structuration to adjacent regions	Edge as dynamics
Dewey	problem formulation, identification of relations among elements within felt difficulty	Edge as problematization
Peirce	abduction, a creative leap from surprising fact to hypothesis	Edge as creative leap
Merleau-Ponty	reversibility / chiasm, the crossing of toucher and touched	Edge as reversible contact
Gadamer	question, arising at the boundary between fore-understanding and otherness	Edge as the site of questioning
Nishida	absolute contradictory self-identity, simultaneous retention of contradictory elements	Edge as retention of contradiction

These six descriptions illuminate Edge from different angles and show that its many-sidedness cannot be captured by a single definition.

6.2 Dissolution of the Distinction Between Genesis of Understanding and Genesis of Being

At the outset of the investigation, a major axis of evaluation seemed likely to be the distinction between genesis of understanding and genesis of being. Husserl's passive synthesis appears to describe constitution of meaning in consciousness, while Simondon's individuation describes the genesis of being itself.

Yet several theories dissolved that distinction from within. Dewey argues that inquiry does not merely recognize a situation, but transforms it. For Merleau-Ponty, perception is production of the world. Nishida's acting intuition shows the inseparability of knowing and making. Simondon also says that cognition itself must be individuated.

The investigation therefore suggests that the creation described by the five-stage model includes both the genesis of understanding and the genesis of being in one broader process.

6.3 Two Modes of Control Over Bundle

Philosophy offers two different control mechanisms against the risk that Bundle becomes rigid.

In Whitehead's process philosophy, an actual occasion loses subjective immediacy once concrescence is complete and becomes data for subsequent occasions. This is a natural control through irreversible structural advance.

By contrast, Adorno's negative dialectics criticizes the conceptual violence involved in Bundle formation. When a concept captures an object, the nonidentical element that cannot be fully absorbed by the concept is suppressed. Adorno therefore demands that Bundle be held only provisionally and always subjected to renewed critique. This is an ethical and critical mode of control.

The former is a descriptive claim that Bundle structurally passes into the next Field. The latter is a normative claim that remaining too long in Bundle becomes violent and that return to Field is therefore necessary.

6.4 Multiplicity of Field

Correspondence at the level of Field was not uniform. At least three levels can be distinguished.

- **Empirical Field**: Husserl's passive background, Dewey's situation or conditions
- **Ontological Field**: Simondon's preindividual state, Whitehead's actual world
- **Ultimate Field**: Nishida's place of absolute nothingness

At present it remains unsettled at which of these levels the Field of the five-stage model should be located.

7. Unresolved Questions

The following questions remained unanswered, or still carry competing interpretations.

1. **The problem that anything might correspond to anything**: Philosophy is a domain of high abstraction, so it is always possible to object that in principle any theory can be mapped onto the five stages in some way. Does the high correspondence rate, nine out of eleven, show a genuine affinity between philosophy and the five-stage model, or does it only show that abstract theories are pliable enough to be fitted to anything? A final answer will require comparison with the other twenty-nine domains.

2. **Critique of linearity**: Deleuze and Guattari, and in another way Adorno, both challenge the very stage-based character of the five-stage model. Rhizomatic thought proposes a

nonhierarchical structure in which any point can connect to any point, and therefore resists reading as a directed process. The risk that the five-stage model hardens into a linear sequence is a philosophically serious criticism.

3. **The level of Field**: Nishida's place of absolute nothingness may function as a place enveloping the entire five-stage model and therefore exceed the scope of Field in the ordinary sense. Whether Field in the five-stage model is empirical, ontological, or ultimate remains unresolved.

4. **Structural similarity versus similarity of labels**: Whitehead's actual world is an already structured past, and is therefore different in character from Field as undifferentiated initial state. In cases like this, one must ask whether the correspondence is structural identity or only similarity in label.

8. Conclusion

The results of the investigation into structural similarity between philosophy and the five-stage model can be summarized as follows.

Structural similarity was confirmed broadly. Nine of the eleven theories showed strong structural correspondence, and two showed conditional correspondence. None showed no correspondence at all.

Theories showing especially strong correspondence: Simondon's theory of individuation showed the deepest correspondence because it describes, in a different vocabulary, the same scope as the five-stage model, namely the process of the genesis of being itself. Dewey provides the only theory in which five stages are explicitly listed in a primary text, which minimizes arbitrariness of mapping.

The many-sided description of Edge: Philosophy proved to be a domain capable of describing Edge from six distinct angles, and therefore provides some of the richest material for deepening understanding of the central concept of Edge.

Critical function: Deleuze and Guattari, together with Adorno, do not merely support the five-stage model through structural correspondence. They also provide philosophical warnings against the model becoming rigid. That critical function is important for preserving the flexibility of the model itself.

At the same time, the risk created by philosophy's high level of abstraction, namely that anything may correspond to anything, cannot be eliminated completely. Whether the correspondences presented here reflect an essential affinity between philosophy and the five-stage model or simply the flexibility of abstract theory will need to be tested through full comparison across all thirty domains.

In terms of firmness of evidence, the correspondences with Simondon and Dewey are the most solid. Gadamer, Peirce, Merleau-Ponty, Husserl, Adorno, and Nishida remain highly persuasive. Whitehead still leaves the problem of constraining purely verbal resemblance. Schelling and Deleuze-Guattari remain at the level of hypothesis.